as the earliest example of Tamil literature. It is credited to a scholar named Tholkappiyar, who is said to have lived in the Kanyakumari country at the time of the great flood and to have based his *Tolkappiyam* on Agathya's lost grammar. It is further said that Tholkappiyar was one of Agathya's twelve disciples, although nowhere in his grammar does he mention the name of his supposed guru.

However, much of what we know about the Tamil Agathya actually comes from a commentary on the *Tolkappiyam* written by a celebrated fourteenth-century Tamil scholar named Nachinarkiniyar.[10] In this commentary Nachinarkiniyar sets out the now familiar story of Shiva's wedding, the tilting of the world and Agathya's journey south at Shiva's request. But he also provides some additional details, presumed to be from earlier lost sources, which describe how on his way south from the Himalayas Agathya visited a place called Tuvarapati, which our commentator identifies as the coastal city of Dwaraka in Gujarat, one of India's *sapta puri* or 'seven holy cities', but also a city famously linked to its founder, Lord Krishna. One of the later avatars or manifestations of Lord Vishnu, Krishna takes his name from the Sanskrit *krsna*, meaning 'dark' or 'black', hence his standard depiction as blue-skinned. Krishna gets no mention in the Vedas, but comes into his own in the *Mahabharata*, which is where we first hear about his city of Dwaraka – as a mighty city lost to the sea in a great inundation. 'On the same day that Krishna departed from the earth,' declares the *Vishnu Purana*, 'the oceans rose and submerged the whole of Dwaraka.' Nachinarkiniyar makes no mention of a flood but tells us that at Dwaraka our sage Agathya collected the descendants of Netu-muti-annal, who could be Krishna but could equally be some other ancestral leader. These descendants included eighteen kings and eighteen families 'of the *Velir* and the *Aruvalar*'. He then leads these migrants